This did not bring much relief to the senior managers either. The message, however, was unambiguous.

The year was also especially remarkable for the way Ratan pushed hard on all fronts to take the group companies on a higher growth trajectory, adopting bolder initiatives. During the presentation he gave that year, he summed up the strategies that he had emphasized since taking over. He advised the senior management of the group to: ‘Question the unquestioned’, ‘Don’t compare with your own past performance’, ‘Redefine the way you conduct business’, ‘Satisfy your customer at all times’, and ‘Lead, never follow’. He drove home this message in subsequent AGMMs as well.

Ratan’s relentless push led the Tata companies to vigorously implement the priorities underlined by the chairman. This had its impact. Companies strove to win the JRD QV Award. The upshot was a significant improvement in their performance.

The programme itself was dynamic. Its components and strategies witnessed changes to accommodate the needs of the time. Sunil Sinha, CEO, TQMS, said that the TBEM process was further improved and it recognized ‘the changing business needs of our companies’. In 2003, corporate governance and knowledge management were made part of the TBEM. Sustainability, climate change and issues of safety were introduced in 2009. These additions once again reflected Ratan’s understanding, much ahead of others, of the concerns that the society would soon be called upon to grapple with and his sensitivity on these issues. From 2011–12, there was a significant thrust on digitization and technology. And 2015 saw customer promise embedded into the criteria.

The evidence of the TBEM model’s efficacy as a change facilitator is unmistakable. Those that had striven to win the award grew in size—Tata Chemicals had become the world’s second-largest producer of soda ash; Tata Motors became the fifth-largest producer of commercial vehicles in the world; Titan rose to be the fifth-largest producer of watches in the world; Tata Steel the world’s sixth-largest producer of steel; and TCS became the number one information services company in Asia. Remarkably, in 2008, nearly all the profit after tax of the group came from its companies that had scored over 500 points in the TBEM, and 81 per cent from JRD QV Award winners.